

A Bright Line That Binds on Few: The NBA's 65-Game Rule and Star Availability

Supplementary material

Appendix A. Additional Tables and Figures

Tables A1 to A19 and Figures A1 to A3 are referenced in the text of the main manuscript. Table and figure sources are listed in the Markdown source of the manuscript.

Table A1*Star player-seasons around the 65-game threshold, pre- vs post-rule*

Qualifying games	Pre: n	Pre: share	Post: n	Post: share
<58	95	0.291	42	0.318
58-64 (below)	40	0.122	15	0.114
65-68 (just above)	41	0.125	14	0.106
69+	151	0.462	61	0.462

Note:

Stars, 2020-2021 excluded. Pre-rule 2014-2019 and 2022-2023; post-rule 2024-2026.

Table A2*Healthy at-risk stars at team game 62: did they reach 65?*

Slack at game 62	Pre: n	Pre: reached 65	Post: n	Post: reached 65	Fisher p
0-2	20	0.40	2	1.00	0.19
3-5	27	0.70	8	0.62	0.69
6-8	25	0.60	11	0.64	1.00

Note:

At risk: 0-8 games of slack at team game 62 (qualifying games so far plus games left minus 65). Healthy: played at least two of games 60-62. Reached: ≥ 65 qualifying games at season end. Fisher exact test of pre vs post.

Table A3*Post-rule change in the probability that an at-risk star reaches 65*

Sample	n	Post n	Pre reach	Post reach	Post: est (SE)	MDE
All at-risk stars	116	34	0.56	0.53	-0.05 (0.10)	0.28
Healthy at game 62	93	21	0.58	0.67	0.06 (0.13)	0.35
Healthy, with current-season contention control	93	21	0.58	0.67	0.14 (0.13)	0.36
Healthy, slack 0-5	57	10	0.57	0.70	0.13 (0.17)	0.48

Note:

Linear probability models with slack-bin controls; SEs clustered by player. MDE at 80% power, in probability points.

Table A4*State x post-rule regressions of late-season absence, stars*

Specification	Term	Est (SE)	p	MDE
state main effects + state x post	secured	0.006 (0.013)	0.61	0.036
state main effects + state x post	secured x post	-0.011 (0.019)	0.56	0.053
no-incentive + no-incentive x post	no incentive	-0.004 (0.012)	0.73	0.034
no-incentive + no-incentive x post	no incentive x post	-0.005 (0.019)	0.78	0.053

Note:

Player-season and team-game-number fixed effects; SEs clustered by player. Reference state: reachable. MDE at 80% power. The unreachable state is omitted: within a player-season its games follow a long absence, so the within-player contrast is mechanically negative and the post interaction is identified from few transitions; Table 6a carries that state.

Table A5*Star minus non-star late-season absence by season*

Season	Full, ref 2023: est (SE)	MDE	Full, ref 2017: est (SE)	MDE	ESPN rows only, ref 2023: est (SE)	MDE
2014	NA	NA	NA	NA	0.023 (0.014)	0.038
2015	0.010 (0.020)	0.057	0.008 (0.019)	0.054	0.009 (0.014)	0.040
2016	0.001 (0.022)	0.062	-0.002 (0.021)	0.058	0.023 (0.015)	0.041
2017	0.006 (0.018)	0.049	0.000 (0.000)	0.000	0.018 (0.012)	0.034
2018	0.005 (0.020)	0.056	0.003 (0.019)	0.053	-0.002 (0.011)	0.032
2019	0.035 (0.022)	0.062	0.033 (0.022)	0.061	-0.001 (0.015)	0.043
2022	0.031 (0.020)	0.057	0.029 (0.021)	0.060	0.012 (0.013)	0.036
2023	0.000 (0.000)	0.000	-0.008 (0.021)	0.059	0.000 (0.000)	0.000
2024	-0.008 (0.018)	0.050	-0.010 (0.020)	0.055	-0.009 (0.008)	0.023
2025	-0.017 (0.025)	0.069	-0.019 (0.026)	0.074	-0.005 (0.014)	0.039
2026	-0.018 (0.024)	0.068	-0.020 (0.025)	0.071	-0.021 (0.010)	0.029

Note:

Coefficients on star x season; player, season and team-game-number fixed effects; SEs clustered by player. 'ESPN rows only' reproduces the exploratory construction in which only games with an ESPN row enter.

Table A6

Spells of 10 or more consecutive missed games, stars and high-minute non-stars

Group	Period	Player-seasons	Spells	Spells per star-season	Star-seasons with a spell	Mean length	Games lost per star-season	Censored at season end	Reason: injury/illness	Reason: no row	Reason: rest or coach	Begin games 1-20	21-40	41-55	56-82
Stars	Pre-rule	327	127	0.39	33%	25.6	10.0	31%	30%	56%	11%	35%	25%	18%	21%
Stars	Post-rule	132	65	0.49	39%	22.2	11.0	34%	20%	77%	0%	34%	11%	25%	31%
High-minute non-stars (prior season)	Pre-rule	542	213	0.39	34%	24.0	9.4	39%	32%	54%	12%	38%	16%	14%	32%
High-minute non-stars (prior season)	Post-rule	239	111	0.46	38%	19.9	9.2	32%	32%	62%	3%	35%	25%	14%	26%

Note:
Full team schedule, 2020-2021 excluded. Reason taken from the first game in the spell for which ESPN printed a row; 'no row' spells have no ESPN row at any point.

Table A7*Decomposition of the 2023 to 2024 change in mean games: stayers, entrants and leavers*

Outcome	Mean 2023 (n)	Mean 2024 (n)	Raw change	Stayers: n	Stayers 2023	Stayers 2024	Stayers change	Entrants 2024 (n)	Leavers 2023 (n)
Stars: games played	59.4 (45)	65.0 (46)	5.6	39	61.3	64.2	2.9	69.6 (7)	46.7 (6)
Stars: qualifying games	58.4 (45)	64.5 (46)	6.1	39	60.6	63.7	3.0	69.3 (7)	44.2 (6)
High-minute non-stars (prior season): games played	65.6 (82)	66.1 (90)	0.6	50	69.7	66.0	-3.8	66.4 (40)	59.1 (32)

Note:

Stayers are players in the group in both seasons; entrants are 2024 members who were not members in 2023; leavers are 2023 members who were not members in 2024. The within-player event-study coefficient is identified from stayers.

Table A8*Fixed-cohort difference-in-differences for each pair of adjacent seasons, games played*

Seasons	Stars (n)	Stars: first, second	Controls (n)	Controls: first, second	DiD: est (SE)	p	MDE
2015->2016	42	64.7, 67.5	85	66.3, 65.0	4.15 (3.77)	0.27	10.6
2016->2017	42	70.5, 69.0	69	67.4, 66.2	-0.31 (3.06)	0.92	8.6
2017->2018	39	70.8, 63.3	74	66.2, 62.2	-3.59 (3.89)	0.36	10.9
2018->2019	36	64.2, 63.3	72	63.9, 63.3	-0.31 (5.16)	0.95	14.5
2022->2023	38	58.4, 60.1	73	61.1, 63.7	-0.92 (3.93)	0.82	11.0
2023->2024	44	60.5, 63.3	80	65.8, 63.9	4.66 (3.44)	0.18	9.6
2024->2025	46	65.0, 63.0	86	66.9, 61.0	3.91 (3.32)	0.24	9.3
2025->2026	43	62.5, 52.9	79	61.5, 57.0	-5.16 (4.64)	0.27	13.0

Note:

Groups fixed at their status in the first season of the pair; players present in both seasons; player and season fixed effects; SEs clustered by player. The 2023 to 2024 row is the year the rule took effect.

Table A9*The maximal-effect bound under alternative definitions of the at-risk population*

Slack measured at game	Window	Period	At risk per season	Share of stars	Did not reach	Bound, minimal crossing	Bound, play every game
55	0-12	Pre-rule	16.8	0.41	6.0	1.07	2.42
55	0-12	Post-rule	20.7	0.47	7.3	1.71	3.79
55	0-8	Pre-rule	9.5	0.23	4.6	0.89	1.55
55	0-8	Post-rule	9.7	0.22	5.3	1.30	2.10
62	0-12	Pre-rule	17.9	0.44	5.4	0.75	2.05
62	0-12	Post-rule	20.3	0.46	5.7	0.99	2.55
62	0-8	Pre-rule	10.2	0.25	4.5	0.67	1.28
62	0-8	Post-rule	11.3	0.26	5.3	0.98	1.83

Note:

Same construction as Table 5c with slack measured at team game 62 or 55 and the window widened to 0-12 games.

Table A10*Finishing at exactly 65 qualifying games among stars who reached the line*

Sample	Period	n	Finished at exactly 65	Share	Mean final qualifying games	Fisher p
all star reachers	Pre-rule	192	9	0.05	73.7	0.16
all star reachers	Post-rule	75	7	0.09	72.7	0.16
at-risk reachers	Pre-rule	46	8	0.17	67.3	0.19
at-risk reachers	Post-rule	18	6	0.33	67.8	0.19
healthy at-risk reachers	Pre-rule	42	8	0.19	67.1	0.27
healthy at-risk reachers	Post-rule	14	5	0.36	67.9	0.27

Note:

At-risk: 0-8 games of slack at team game 62. Healthy: played at least two of games 60-62. Fisher exact test of pre vs post within sample.

Table A11*Final qualifying games of at-risk stars who reached 65*

Final qualifying games	Pre: n	Pre: share	Post: n	Post: share
65	8	0.17	6	0.33
66	13	0.28	0	0.00
67	7	0.15	2	0.11
68	8	0.17	3	0.17
69	3	0.07	1	0.06
70	2	0.04	4	0.22
71	3	0.07	1	0.06
72	2	0.04	1	0.06

Table A12*Long absences beginning in the late-season window, before and after the rule*

Group	Period	Spells	Beginning at game 56+	Share	Fisher p (pre vs post)
Stars	Pre-rule	127	27	0.21	0.16
Stars	Post-rule	65	20	0.31	0.16
High-minute non-stars (prior season)	Pre-rule	213	69	0.32	0.25
High-minute non-stars (prior season)	Post-rule	111	29	0.26	0.25

Note:

Difference in shares, stars minus control, post minus pre: 0.158 with bootstrap 95% interval [-0.012, 0.329] from 2,000 resamples of spells within group and period.

Table A13

ESPN box-score rows against Basketball-Reference did-not-play and inactive lists, sample games

Season	Game	ESPN rows	BBR box rows	ESPN rows found in BBR box	ESPN DNP rows	Of which BBR did-not-play	BBR inactive	BBR inactive with an ESPN row	Star with no ESPN row	On BBR inactive list
2015	2014-12-03	26	68	26	6	6	3	0	DeMar DeRozan	TRUE
2017	2016-12-28	26	68	26	7	7	4	0	Damian Lillard	TRUE
2019	2018-11-15	25	67	25	4	4	8	0	Pau Gasol	TRUE
2023	2023-01-31	28	70	28	8	8	6	0	Zion Williamson	TRUE
2024	2024-01-15	25	67	25	7	7	9	0	Jaylen Brown	TRUE
2025	2025-03-15	25	67	25	3	3	11	0	Ja Morant	TRUE
2026	2026-03-07	26	68	26	5	5	10	0	Jaren Jackson Jr.	TRUE

Note:

One game per season, chosen so that a star has an ESPN no-row absence. BBR box scores list did-not-play and did-not-dress players inside the box and inactive players below it.

Table A14

Games played: ten star-seasons checked against Basketball-Reference

Season	Player	Reference games played	This paper: regular season	Raw ESPN count	Games under the rule (incl. Cup final)	Qualifying games	Status	Source
2024	Joel Embiid	39	39	39	39	39	match	web lookup 2026-09-15 (ESPN game log, StatMuse); BBR not re-requested
2024	Tyrese Haliburton	69	69	71	70	69	match	cached BBR awards_2024.html (MVP and All-NBA voting tables, G column)
2023	Stephen Curry	56	56	56	56	56	match	cached BBR awards_2023.html (MVP voting table, G column)
2025	Luka Doncic	50	50	50	50	50	match	web lookup 2026-09-15 (22 DAL + 28 LAL); BBR not re-requested
2024	Nikola Jokic	79	79	80	79	79	match	cached BBR awards_2024.html (MVP voting table, G column)
2023	LeBron James	55	55	56	55	55	match	cached BBR awards_2023.html (All-NBA voting table, G column)
2022	Kawhi Leonard	0					no ESPN rows; not in sample	missed the entire 2021-22 season (ACL); web lookup 2026-09-15
2024	Jimmy Butler	60	60	60	60	60	match	web lookup 2026-09-15; BBR not re-requested
2024	Donovan Mitchell	55	55	56	55	55	match	web lookup 2026-09-15 (StatMuse); BBR not re-requested
2026	Victor Wembanyama	64	64	67	65	65	match	cached BBR awards_2026.html (MVP, DPOY, All-NBA voting tables, G column)

Note:

Reference values from cached Basketball-Reference award-voting tables where available, otherwise from a web lookup on the date shown. Regular-season games exclude the All-Star game and the NBA Cup final, as Basketball-Reference does; the rule's count includes the Cup final.

Table A15*Effect of removing All-Star and Rising Stars rows on star counts*

Season	Stars	GP changed	QG changed	Mean GP, raw	Mean GP, clean	Mean QG, raw	Mean QG, clean	Crossed 65 only via exhibition
2014	41	18	10	60.7	60.3	58.2	57.9	0
2015	43	16	11	63.5	63.2	61.1	60.9	0
2016	46	20	16	69.5	69.1	66.4	66.0	0
2017	40	21	17	70.8	70.2	66.7	66.3	0
2018	36	18	15	64.7	64.2	62.6	62.2	0
2019	37	19	13	63.6	63.1	61.9	61.6	1
2022	39	15	10	58.5	58.1	56.9	56.7	0
2023	45	16	14	59.7	59.4	58.8	58.4	1
2024	46	19	14	65.5	65.0	64.8	64.5	0
2025	46	16	0	63.1	62.4	62.0	62.0	0
2026	40	18	0	56.1	54.8	54.4	54.4	0

Note:

Games played also exclude the NBA Cup final (a non-regular-season game for statistics); qualifying games include it, as the rule does.

Table A16*Minutes played by late-season stars, by slack: share of player-games (cell count)*

Sample	Minutes	pre, not tight	pre, tight	post, not tight	post, tight
All	<15	0.018 (103)	0.010 (7)	0.007 (16)	0.000 (0)
All	15-19	0.030 (173)	0.031 (22)	0.010 (22)	0.011 (2)
All	20-22	0.037 (211)	0.042 (30)	0.026 (57)	0.043 (8)
All	23-30	0.243 (1385)	0.294 (209)	0.215 (470)	0.368 (68)
All	31+	0.671 (3823)	0.623 (442)	0.742 (1622)	0.578 (107)
Played each of previous 3 games	<15	0.013 (58)	0.013 (7)	0.004 (7)	0.000 (0)
Played each of previous 3 games	15-19	0.021 (98)	0.033 (17)	0.009 (15)	0.000 (0)
Played each of previous 3 games	20-22	0.031 (142)	0.034 (18)	0.026 (43)	0.034 (4)
Played each of previous 3 games	23-30	0.239 (1090)	0.295 (154)	0.202 (340)	0.325 (38)
Played each of previous 3 games	31+	0.696 (3176)	0.625 (326)	0.759 (1275)	0.641 (75)

Note:

Stars who played, games 56 onward, 2020-2021 excluded. Tight: 0-3 games of slack and 65 not yet secured. Cell counts in parentheses. Confounded by minute restrictions on players returning from injury.

Table A17*What ESPN says about late-season absences of stars who played the previous game*

Period	Class	n	Share
Pre-rule	no row (reason unknown)	345	54.9%
Pre-rule	injury or illness	113	18.0%
Pre-rule	coach's decision	107	17.0%
Pre-rule	rest	52	8.3%
Pre-rule	other	11	1.8%
Post-rule	no row (reason unknown)	221	81.0%
Post-rule	injury or illness	41	15.0%
Post-rule	rest	7	2.6%
Post-rule	other	4	1.5%

Note:

Classes from the DNP reason string. Absences with no ESPN row carry no reason.

Table A18

Flagged stars absent from the sample: no ESPN box-score row in the season

Season	Flagged stars with no ESPN appearance
2015	Andrew Bynum
2017	Chris Bosh; Kobe Bryant; Tim Duncan
2018	Chris Bosh; Kobe Bryant; Tim Duncan
2019	Kobe Bryant
2020	Dirk Nowitzki; Dwyane Wade; John Wall; Kevin Durant; Klay Thompson
2021	Dirk Nowitzki; Dwyane Wade; Klay Thompson
2022	Dirk Nowitzki; Dwyane Wade; Kawhi Leonard; Zion Williamson
2026	Kyrie Irving; Tyrese Haliburton

Note:

Retired players and players who missed the entire season. They do not enter any player-season count.

Table A19*Late-season 'rest' rates computed on ESPN rows only (exploratory construction)*

Season	Stars: share sat (ESPN rows only)	Contemporaneous control: share sat (ESPN rows only)	Star player-games	Control player-games
2014	0.071	0.030	776	2301
2015	0.058	0.041	824	1721
2016	0.068	0.037	981	1809
2017	0.055	0.030	851	1773
2018	0.028	0.024	713	1630
2019	0.036	0.030	758	1693
2022	0.032	0.027	709	1834
2023	0.011	0.021	842	2110
2024	0.017	0.032	906	1739
2025	0.042	0.054	835	1372
2026	0.014	0.036	633	1486

Note:

Player-games with an ESPN row whose previous ESPN row was a game played, games 56 onward; the outcome is a did-not-play row. This construction omits inactive-list absences and tracks roster designation (Table 2); it is shown only to document the earlier numbers.

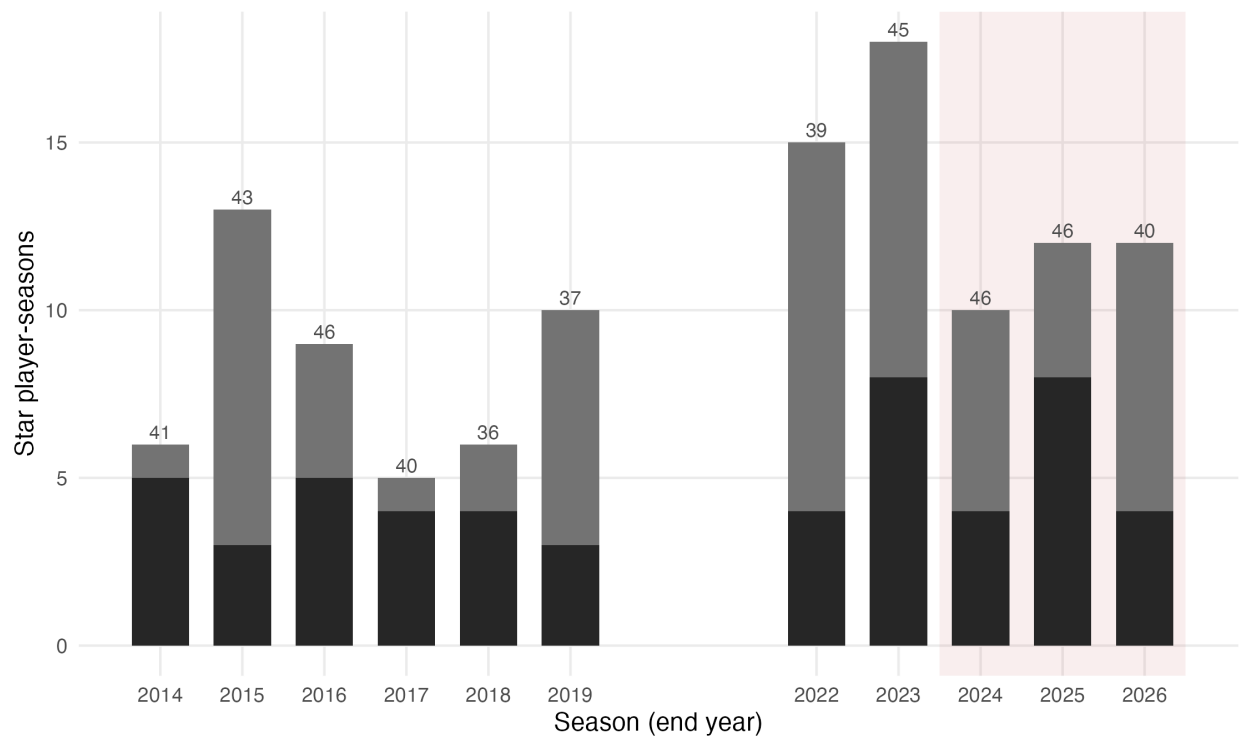


Figure A1. Stars at risk at team game 62 (slack 0-8), by season; black: at risk and did not reach 65; number above bar: stars that season.

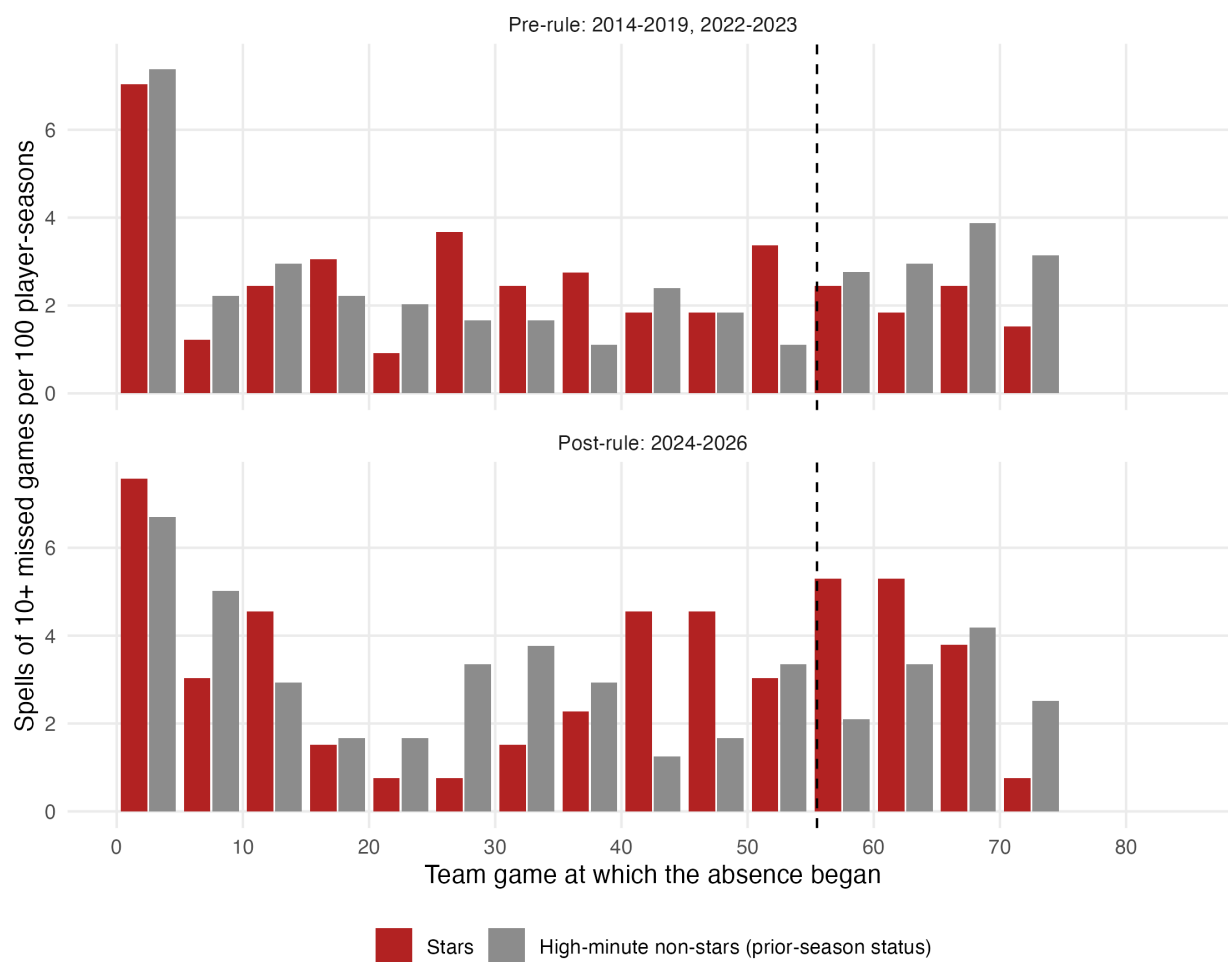


Figure A2. Team game at which spells of 10 or more missed games began, per 100 player-seasons, stars and control, before and after the rule.

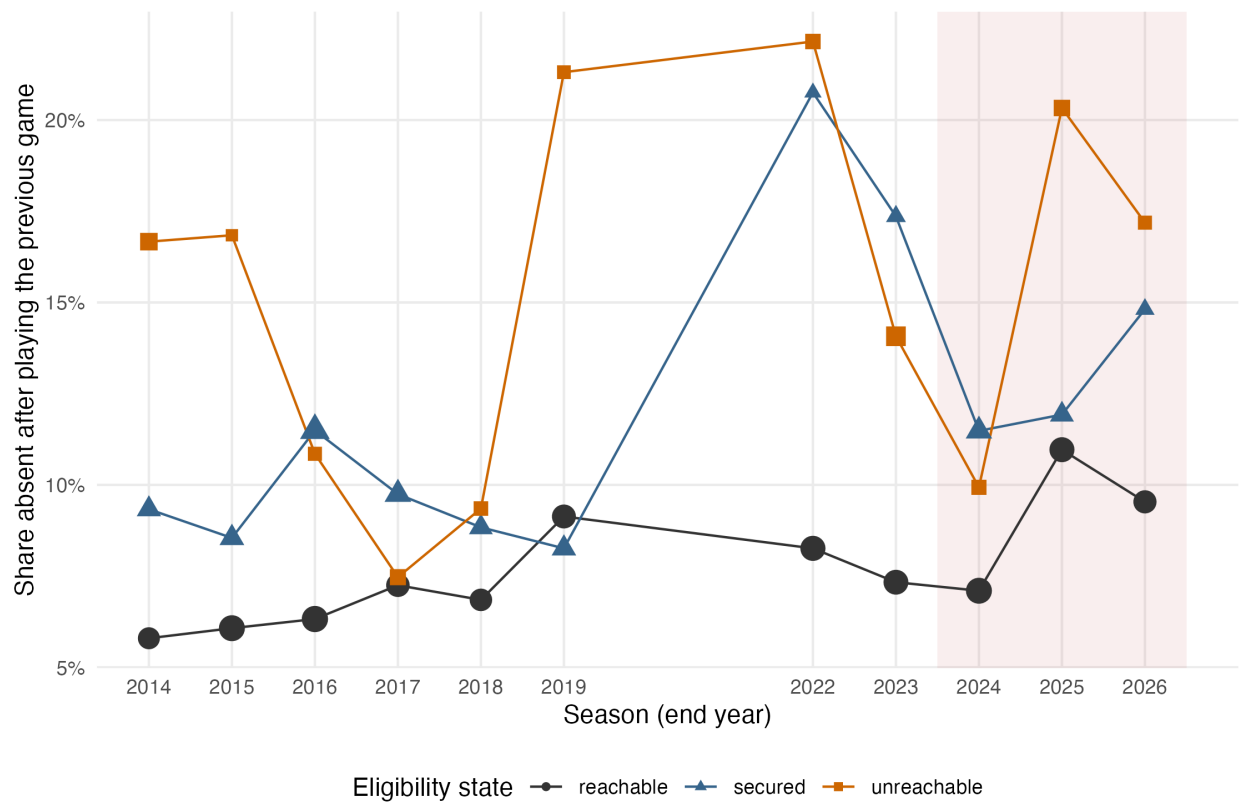


Figure A3. Late-season absence of stars who played the previous game, by eligibility state and season; point size is the number of player-games in the cell.